

influence on German music he decried. While pursuing these ideas, he supported himself by borrowing large sums from adoring women.

By 1853, Wagner had written the text for *Der Ring des Nibelungen*, a cycle of four operas based on Nordic sagas. The music for the first two, *Das Rheingold* and *Die Walküre*, was completed by 1856. These works were aligned with his theoretical writing, which saw music as subordinate to the poetic text. But in the mid-1850s, he discovered the philosophy of Arthur Schopenhauer—Buddhist-influenced, and positing music as the highest of the arts. He also discovered Otto and Mathilde Wesendonck. Otto was a silk merchant who became another of Wagner's admiring benefactors; his wife, a poet, became the composer's muse and possibly his lover. He played her the singular compliment of setting her verse, rather than his own, in his *Wesendonck-Lieder* (1858). Above all, she was the inspiration for *Tristan und Isolde*, his opera of love and death, completed during spells in Venice and Lucerne in 1858–1859. In *Tristan*, the passionate music dominates the drama. Its unresolved yearning harmonies, failing to establish a clear tonality, are often seen as the starting point of musical Modernism.

